



Mangafont

マンガフォント

A Latin alphabet drawn in katakana — the script Japanese uses for foreign words — with a hiragana hand laid over it, and the katakana themselves in the same face, so ラーメン and RAMEN can be set in one typeface.

MANGAFONT TEXT REGULAR · CONTRAST 0.60

Enrico Bruni

MANGAFONT TEXT BOLD · CONTRAST 0.64

Enrico Bruni

MANGAFONT REGULAR · CONTRAST 0.44

Enrico Bruni

MANGAFONT BOLD · CONTRAST 0.51

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Japanese has three scripts and uses them for different jobs.

Katakana is the one for foreign words — ラーメン, コーヒー, エンリコ・ブルーニ. So a Latin alphabet meant to read as Japanese should be drawn as katakana rather than as kanji: katakana is what a Japanese reader's eye already associates with foreign text.

That changes the drawing, not only the flavour. Katakana are one to four strokes, sparse and open; 口 is the only one that closes. Kanji are dense, often ten to twenty strokes packed into a grid. A Latin face built on kanji logic comes out as a wall of boxes. Built on katakana logic it comes out sparse, diagonal and open — which is what this is.

FOUR THINGS CARRY IT

SWEEPS

Katakana have so few strokes that each one must carry the character, so it runs the width of the square and tapers to a needle. Every diagonal here is a 払い at that length — A K M N R V W X Y Z and their lowercase.

THE フ TURN

A hairline meets a hard 肩 corner and sweeps away. It is how フ ㇿ ク ス ズ ム ㇾ all begin, and it builds ㇿ, ㇺ, ㇻ, ㇼ and ㇽ.

CONTRAST

A 横画 is a hairline and a 縦画 is a slab — 46 units against 104 in the display cut, a ratio of 0.44. This is the loudest signal in the script.

FIT

The glyphs fill the square. Cap height is 790 of a 1000 em and the x-height is 600 — 0.76 of the cap, far higher than any Latin face — so lowercase sits square as kana do.

LETTERS DRAWN AS THEIR COUNTERPARTS

LATIN FROM CONSTRUCTION

X	×	one 払い crossed by another — the same character
ㇿ	フ	a hairline meets a 肩 corner and sweeps away
ㇺ	ズ	the same turn, landing on a floor
ㇽ	ㇾ	a crossbar that runs past its stem
ㇼ	ㇻ	left stem turns along the floor

LATIN FROM CONSTRUCTION

ㇾ	ㇿ	turns at the foot and flicks up
ㇽ	ㇾ	slab top and bottom, holding the square
ㇼ	ㇽ	the only katakana that closes
ㇻ	ㇼ	a ㇽ, finishing with ㇽ's flick
ㇺ	ㇻ	a fold hung on a stem, never an arch

A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z

a b c d e f g h i j k l m n o p q r s t u v w x y z

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 & @ # \$ %

.,:;!?' " () [] { } < > / \ | - - - _ ~

^ ` * + =

ア イ ウ エ オ カ キ ク ケ コ サ シ ス セ ソ タ チ ツ テ ト

ナ ニ ス ネ ノ ハ ヒ フ ヘ ホ マ ミ ム ヨ モ ヤ ヲ ユ ラ リ

ル レ ロ ワ ヲ ャ ュ ユ ヲ ヱ ヲ ヱ ヲ ヱ ヲ

ガ ギ グ ゲ ゴ ザ ジ ズ セ ソ ダ デ ズ デ ド バ ビ ブ ベ ボ

パ ピ プ ペ ポ ヱ

ア イ ウ エ オ ヲ ャ ュ ユ ヲ

The complete U+30A1-U+30F4 block. Foreign words need all of it: プルーニ needs プ, and ティ, ギ and ジェ need the small kana. The voiced and small forms are derived from the base drawings rather than redrawn, so they follow the weight axis and inherit any later correction to a base letter.

Tokyo Night Market

Ramen, gyoza and cold beer

The brush lifts and leaves a flag behind it

Every horizontal climbs about two degrees to the right, as a hand does

Katakana have so few strokes that each one has to carry the character, so it runs the full width of the square and tapers away to a needle point.

Pack my box with five dozen liquor jugs — 0123456789 — waltz, nymph, for quick jigs vex Bud.
The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog.

Tokyo Night Market

The same words, with the hairlines let out

At display sizes the contrast can run to 0.44, which is where Mincho keeps it. Below about twelve point those hairlines start to break down, which is what the text cut is for.

MANGAFONT TEXT REGULAR · 9.8 PT

Katakana is the script Japanese uses for foreign words. A Latin alphabet meant to read as Japanese should therefore be drawn as katakana rather than as kanji, because katakana is what a reader's eye already associates with foreign text.

That is a structural claim, not a decorative one. Katakana are one to four strokes, sparse and open, and α is the only character that closes. A face built on kanji logic comes out dense; built on katakana logic it comes out airy and diagonal.

The text cut lowers the contrast so the hairlines survive, thickens the terminals, and quiets the pressure modulation. It is an optical size, not a lighter weight.

BOLD

MANGAFONT TEXT BOLD

Contrast falls as weight rises, because it does in Mincho too. Holding 0.44 into a bold would leave hairlines that snap at any real size, so the bolds sit at 0.51 and 0.64.

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The display cut keeps the contrast high, at 0.44. Set large it is the more elegant of the two; set small its horizontals thin out, which is the trade the text cut exists to solve.

MANGAFONT BOLD

Terminals grow sub-proportionally, on a 0.72 power law. An うろこ scaled linearly into a bold swallows the letter it is sitting on.

Drawing the kana first is what the Latin was calibrated against. The **M** of RAMEN and the **x** of ラーメン are the same two strokes.

SIGNAGE

ラーメン RAMEN

NAME, BOTH SCRIPTS

エンリコ・ブルーニ Enrico Bruni

LOANWORDS

コーヒー COFFEE ・ ビール BEER ・ パン
BREAD

SMALL KANA AT WORK

ティー TEA ・ ヴィラ VILLA ・ ジェット JET

BOLD, DISPLAY

トウキョウ 1985 TOKYO

TEXT CUT, MIXED RUNNING LINE

Latin and katakana only, not kanji: 東 falls back to another font, as it does here. ラーメン and ビール do not.

METRICS

MEASURE	VALUE	CUT	STEM	HAIRLINE	CONTRAST
Units per em	1000	Text Regular	96	58	0.60
Cap height	790	Text Bold	156	100	0.64
x-height	600 — 0.76 of cap	Regular	104	46	0.44
Ascender / descender	858 / -170	Bold	168	86	0.51

Metrics are identical across all four cuts, so they can be swapped without reflowing. Katakana are full-width; the Latin is proportional, as in a real Japanese family.